Session 4: Research & Outreach

Sales 101 (Postgraduate) | Account Research, Cold Email and LinkedIn | 90 minutes

Class Agenda

Time	What we are doing	What you produce
0-04	Objectives and how you will know you got there	Nothing. Read the success criteria.
04-16	The four-circle research framework	Notes.
16-36	Workshop 1: build a one-page research brief. Manual first, then AI.	A research brief and a gap list.
36-44	Anatomy of a cold email, and an email autopsy	Notes.
44-69	Workshop 2: write a three-email sequence. Peer review.	Three emails, peer-scored.
69-84	Workshop 3: LinkedIn connection request and first message	Two LinkedIn messages.
84-90	Self-check and closing questions	Answer sheet, handed in.

Key Objectives

#	Objective	What success looks like	Where it is measured
LO1	Build a one-page research brief on a target account using public sources and AI.	Four circles populated. Every entry is something you could use in a sentence to a human being, not a fact you found interesting. You can name at least one trigger.	Framework 1.
LO2	Write a cold email that references something specific about the prospect.	The opening line could not be sent to any other company on the target list. It survives the swap test.	Framework 2, email 1.
LO3	Write a three-email sequence where each follow-up adds new value.	Emails 2 and 3 contain information that was not in email 1. Neither uses the phrase 'just following up' or any variant of it.	Framework 2.
LO4	Distinguish a personalised email from a templated one.	In the autopsy and in peer review you can identify which emails were mail-merged, and say which specific line gives it away.	Email autopsy, peer review.

Part 1: The Four-Circle Framework

Research fails in two directions. Too little and your email is generic. Too much and you spend forty minutes on an account you should have disqualified in four. The framework exists to make research finite: four circles, one pass each, then stop.

Circle	What you are looking for	Where to look	Time
Industry	What is changing in this category right now, and what does that force companies in it to do?	Trade press, a competitor's blog, recent funding news in the category.	3 min
Company	Size, stage, funding, recent moves, and above all a trigger: something that just happened that makes your problem urgent.	Website, LinkedIn company page, press releases, careers page.	8 min
Role	What is this job measured on at a company this size? What breaks first?	Job descriptions for the same role at similar companies.	4 min
Individual	What does this specific person seem to care about, and what have they said publicly?	Their LinkedIn activity, posts, podcast appearances, conference talks.	5 min

THE CIRCLE THAT MATTERS MOST

Company, and specifically the trigger. Everything else is context; the trigger is the reason you are emailing this week rather than next quarter.

For Sprinto, the trigger is almost always the same shape: something has just happened that will cause an enterprise buyer to ask for a SOC 2 report. A funding round that pushes them upmarket. A first US enterprise logo. An enterprise sales hire. A job posting for a compliance role.

A research brief with no trigger is a company profile. It tells you who they are and gives you no reason to write today.

Actionable versus interesting

The test for every line in your brief: could you use this in a sentence to a human being without sounding like you had been reading about them?

Interesting (cut it)	Actionable (keep it)
Founded in 2019 by two ex-Flipkart engineers.	Posted a job last month for their first enterprise account executive.
Raised a Series A in 2023.	Announced their first US customer in January, which is when enterprise security reviews start.
Has 120 employees.	Has 120 employees and no security or compliance role listed anywhere.

Interesting (cut it)	Actionable (keep it)
The founder went to IIT Delhi.	The founder posted three weeks ago about a deal that stalled in a security review.

Part 2: The Case

What you are selling

Sprinto is a compliance automation platform. Founded 2020 in Bengaluru by Girish Redekar and Raghuveer Kancherla. Series B of $20M led by Accel in April 2024, roughly $32M raised in total.

It automates SOC 2, ISO 27001, GDPR, HIPAA, PCI-DSS and over 200 other frameworks: continuous control monitoring, automated evidence collection, an audit-readiness dashboard and a public Trust Centre.

There is no public pricing, no self-serve tier and no free trial. Every deal is a custom quote, bundled rather than seat-based. Published reference pricing starts around $15,000 a year; real quotes run roughly $6,000 to $20,000. Marketing is content-led, but the close is sales-assisted and high touch.

Buyers are security and compliance leads, and founders or CTOs at cloud-native startups who have run into an enterprise buyer's security requirements. Over 3,000 customers across 75 countries. FY24 revenue $6.3M, up from $2.5M the year before.

Its competitors are Vanta, the market share leader, plus Drata, Secureframe and Tugboat Logic. Sprinto positions on price competitiveness and framework breadth rather than integration depth.

Your target list

Pick one. All are real companies you can research now.

Target account	Why it might need Sprinto
Zenskar	Usage-based billing for B2B SaaS. Handles customer revenue data, so enterprise prospects will ask about SOC 2 early.
Procol	Procurement software sold into large Indian manufacturers. Enterprise procurement teams audit their own vendors.
GoKwik	Ecommerce checkout and RTO. Processes payment and address data at scale for D2C brands.
TrueFoundry	ML platform deployed inside enterprises including Fortune 500 accounts. Sells self-hostable for data sovereignty reasons, which signals security-sensitive buyers.
MoveInSync	Employee transport software. Holds location and personal data for corporate clients.
WebEngage	Customer engagement platform with a built-in CDP. Holds behavioural and contact data across India, SEA and the Middle East.

Framework 1: Research Brief

Twenty minutes. First twelve without AI, using only the company website, LinkedIn and search. Then eight minutes with an LLM, and record what it added and what it got wrong.

Circle	What you found	Why it matters for this conversation
Industry		
Company		
Role		
Individual		
THE TRIGGER		

AI pass

Question	Your answer
What did the AI add that you had missed?	
What did it get wrong or invent? Check every specific claim.	
What did you find manually that it could not have found?	

Part 3: Anatomy of a Cold Email

Part	Job	Length	The failure mode
Hook	Prove in one line that this was written for them.	1 line	'I see you're in the compliance space.' True of two hundred companies.
Pain	Name the consequence of the trigger, not the trigger itself.	1-2 lines	Describing your product's benefit and calling it their pain.
Value	One sentence on what changes. Not a feature list.	1-2 lines	Three capabilities and a customer count.
CTA	One specific, small ask.	1 line	'Would you be open to a quick call to explore synergies?'

THE SWAP TEST

Take your email. Replace the company name with another company from the target list.

If it still makes sense, you have written a template. Delete the hook and start again.

This is the single fastest quality check available and it takes four seconds.

Sequence logic

Three emails. The rule is that each one must add information the previous one did not contain. 'Just following up' adds nothing and signals that you had nothing else to say.

Email	Sends	What it adds	What it must not do
1	Day 1	The trigger and its consequence. Your smallest possible ask.	List features. Attach anything.
2	Day 4	New evidence: a peer who had the same trigger, or a specific detail about what the security review will ask for.	Repeat email 1 more politely.
3	Day 10	A different angle entirely, or a clean close that makes it easy to say no.	Guilt. 'I've reached out a few times...'

Framework 2: Three-Email Sequence

Twenty-five minutes. Write all three, then swap with a partner for review.

Email	Subject line	Body
1 (Day 1)		
2 (Day 4)		
3 (Day 10)		

Peer review

Check	Reviewer's verdict
Swap test: does email 1 survive a company-name swap? (It should NOT)	
Does email 2 contain information not in email 1? Quote it.	
Does email 3 add an angle or just repeat?	
Which single line is the weakest, and why?	
Reply or delete?	

Framework 3: LinkedIn

Fifteen minutes. LinkedIn is not email with a shorter character limit. A connection request is a request for permission; the first message is what you do with it.

	Connection request	First message
Length	Under 300 characters. Shorter is better.	Under 100 words.
Job	Give a reason to accept that is not 'I want to sell you something'.	Earn a reply. Not a meeting.
Ask	None. Do not pitch in a connection request.	One question they can answer in a sentence.
Tell	A blank request from a stranger with a sales title gets ignored.	A paragraph about your product gets ignored.

Message	Your words
Connection request	
First message (after they accept)	

Part 4: Check Your Own Learning

Objective	Check yourself	Tick
LO1: Research brief	Look at your five rows. Cross out anything that is interesting but not usable in a sentence. If you cross out more than two, you were reading, not researching.	
LO2: Specific hook	Run the swap test on email 1. If it survives, it fails.	
LO3: Escalating value	Cover the dates and read emails 2 and 3. Could they be reordered without anyone noticing? If yes, neither added anything.	
LO4: Spotting templates	Look at your partner's sequence. Name the one line you are most confident was written for anyone. Tell them.	

THE MOST COMMON WAY TO FAIL THIS SESSION

You do genuinely good research, then write an email that opens with a compliment about their growth and never uses any of it.

Research that does not change a sentence in the email was decoration. The brief is not the deliverable; the first line is.

Closing Questions

Five multiple-choice questions in the last five minutes. Individually and silently.

Before Session 5

Session 5 is the phone. Same product, same target list, and the part of outreach that everyone avoids.